

WI-FI COMPONENTS

We all crave freedom: from wired telephones, wired keyboards, and even wired networks. The Wi-Fi wave reached Indian shores in a big way last year; we reviewed Wi-Fi routers (which enable wireless networking at home) and also Wi-Fi ADSL routers (which let you share your Internet connection wirelessly).

ROUTERS

The Reigning Champion

ASUS WL-530G

This device is small enough to be stuffed inside a trouser pocket. It's not small on features though—DHCP, NAT, VPN-pass through, and all the security features are there. Though not the best we have seen so far, you can make your way around ASUS' software after fiddling around for just a little while. Due to its tiny footprint, we'd recommend it to the hotspot browser on the move.

The Contender

LinkSys WRT54G

This router sports twin antennas. It has four ports with bridging, and supports 802.11 b/g. In terms of security, there is support for NAT and SP1 along with IP blocking and Wireless Isolation and encryption. It outpaced much of the competition in the Zone 1 tests. Though its signal quality is slightly inferior, where this one scores is in pricing: just Rs 3,634.

The Award

ASUS WL-530G

With unmatched speeds in our tests, the ASUS WL-530G is suitable for setting up a home or SoHo wireless office where its data throughput capabilities will be put to good use. It exhibited superior performance in the video streaming test as well—thus you won't have to

sit near your PC if you have one of these. Priced at Rs 4,400, the WL-530G offers excellent value for money. Grab the WL-530G—it is the fastest Wi-Fi router out there, and our Zero1 winner.

ACCESS POINTS

The Reigning Champion

LinkSys WAP54G

This one is the AP equivalent of the WRT54G router. It is wall-mountable, and a kit to implement that is provided. It sports two antennas, so we expected it to have stronger signal strength, and this was indeed the case. An additional feature is bridging capabilities. The firmware interface is identical to that of the WRT54G, apart from the lack of routing functions. Security features such as NAT and SP1 are present, along with almost every other advanced feature such as encryption, wireless isolation, etc.

The Contenders

Senao ECB 3220

The wall-mountable Senao ECB 3220 functions as a wireless bridge and also as an Access Point. In keeping with its primary function (bridge), it showed very good signal strength. It was a steady performer and didn't lose reception in any of the tests—not even while moving between Zones; something unique, because all the other devices in the test, with the exception of the ASUS WL-600G, lost reception while the laptop was being moved between zones, thus reaffirming that the ECB 3220 has a very strong signal. Being an AP, it carries a rather expensive price tag of Rs 8,280, but because of its powerful signal, office users will find it useful as a bridge between two wireless networks.

The Award

LinkSys WAP54G

The LinkSys WAP54G demolished the competition in our data transfer tests. The performance, coupled with the attractive price tag of \$80 (Rs 3,200) makes it a great buy. The remote Web interface is easy to use, and security features are well-integrated in this Access Point—making it a deserving winner of our Zero1 award.

